



Liechtenstein

Perched in the Alps between Switzerland and Austria, the state of Liechtenstein became an independent principality of the Holy Roman Empire in 1719. It has close links with Switzerland.



GEOGRAPHY

The upper Rhine Valley covers the western third of the country. The mountains and narrow valleys of the eastern Alps make up the remainder.



CLIMATE

Warm, dry summers. Winters are cold, with heavy snow in the mountains from December to March.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Principality's role as a financial center accounts for its many foreign residents (a third of the population). Half of the workforce are cross-border commuters. Living standards are high, with few social tensions. Linked by a customs union since 1924, Switzerland handles Liechtenstein's foreign affairs and defense issues.

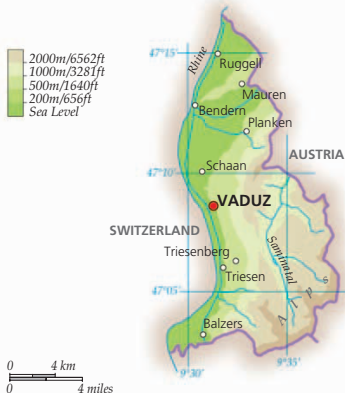


INSIGHT: Women in Liechtenstein obtained the vote only in 1984



THE ECONOMY

Banking secrecy (now modified) and low taxes help attract foreign investment. Anti-money-laundering rules are recent. Diversified exports include precision instruments, dental products, and chemicals.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Principality of Liechtenstein

DATE OF FORMATION: 1719

CAPITAL: Vaduz

POPULATION: 35,000

TOTAL AREA: 62 sq. miles
(160 sq. km)

DENSITY: 565 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: German*, Italian, Alemannish dialect

RELIGIONS: Catholic 81%, other 19%

ETHNIC MIX: Liechtensteiner 66%, other 18%, Swiss 10%, Austrian 6%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Swiss franc = 100 centimes